THE ONTARIO HST SURVIVAL CHECKLIST

The Diaspora Founder’s Guide to Avoiding Audits and Reclaiming Thousands in Hidden Tax Credits.

PREPARED BY

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FOR

Growth-Focused Canadian-Nigerian Tech Founders, Logistics Operators, and High-Growth Health Agencies.

SECTION 1: THE $30,000 HST REGISTRATION TRIGGER

- **Track Gross Revenue Quarterly** — You are legally required to register for an HST account the exact moment your gross taxable sales exceed $30,000 CAD within a single calendar quarter or across four consecutive quarters.

- **The Voluntary Registration Advantage** — If your revenue is under $30,000 but you are investing heavily in setup costs (inventory, laptops, software), register immediately. This allows you to claim tax refunds before you even make your first sale.

- **Audit Check** — If you crossed the $30k mark months ago without registering, stop right now. You will owe the CRA 13% on all those past sales out-of-pocket, even if you never collected it from your clients.

SECTION 2: CLEAN ACCRUAL VS. CASH BOOKKEEPING

- **Identify Your Filing Type** — Ensure your QuickBooks Online dashboard is set to the correct filing method. Most Ontario corporations must report HST on an Accrual Basis (reporting tax based on the invoice date, not when the client actually pays you).

- **Match Filing Frequencies to Cash Flow** — Know your reporting window (Monthly, Quarterly, or Annually). For most fast-growing SMEs, Quarterly filing provides the best balance of administrative ease and cash flow tracking.

SECTION 3: UNLOCKING YOUR INPUT TAX CREDITS (ITCS)

- **Recover Your Setup Hardware** — Did you buy corporate laptops, office chairs, or monitors? Track the 13% tax paid on these items to lower your net remittance liability.

- **Audit-Proof Your Subscriptions** — Ensure software tools (QuickBooks, Slack, Zoom, AWS, Stripe fees) are mapped to hit your ITC ledger automatically.

- **The 50% Meals Rule** — Remember that client dinner meetings are restricted by the CRA. You can only claim 50% of the HST on meals and entertainment.

- **Ditch the Paper Shoebox** — Never rely on faded paper receipts. Connect Dext or Hubdoc to your QBO dashboard so every single tax receipt is scanned, digitized, and legally backed up for the CRA.

IS YOUR ONTARIO LEDGER TRULY CRA-COMPLIANT?

Small bookkeeping classification errors create massive financial liabilities during an audit. Don't scale your business on broken financial data.

Get a Free 15-Minute QBO Dashboard Audit. We will log into your QuickBooks Online account, scan your current HST configuration, and pinpoint any hidden classification errors for free.

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